

Why Are There So Many Variants in the New Testament?

Mathematical Basis for Variants

The large number of textual variants in the New Testament can be attributed to several factors, including word order, definite article inclusion, and spelling variations. Below, we outline the mathematical formulas that explain this variation.

Word Order Permutations

The number of possible arrangements of three words in a sentence is determined by the factorial function:

$$3! = 3 \times 2 \times 1 = 6$$

Definite Article Combinations

Each noun (e.g., "John" and "Mary") may either include or omit the definite article. Given that each name has two possibilities (with or without the article), the total number of combinations is:

$$2^2 = 4$$

Spelling Variations

Each name has two possible spelling variations. The number of ways to vary the spelling is:

$$2 \times 2 = 4$$

Total Variants

Combining these factors, the total number of permutations is:

$$3! \times 2^2 \times 2 \times 2 = 6 \times 4 \times 2 \times 2 = 96$$

The 96 Variants

The following are all the possible textual variants of the phrase "John loves Mary" in Koine Greek, considering word order, definite articles, and spelling variations.

1. ὁ Ἰωάννης ἀγαπᾷ ἡ Μαρίαν
2. ὁ Ἰωάννης ἀγαπᾷ ἡ Μαρίμουν
3. ὁ Ἰωάννης ἀγαπᾷ Μαρίαν
4. ὁ Ἰωάννης ἀγαπᾷ Μαρίμουν
5. Ἰωάννης ἀγαπᾷ ἡ Μαρίαν
6. Ἰωάννης ἀγαπᾷ ἡ Μαρίμουν
7. Ἰωάννης ἀγαπᾷ Μαρίαν
8. Ἰωάννης ἀγαπᾷ Μαρίμουν
9. ὁ Ἰωνῆς ἀγαπᾷ ἡ Μαρίαν
10. ὁ Ἰωνῆς ἀγαπᾷ ἡ Μαρίμουν
11. ὁ Ἰωνῆς ἀγαπᾷ Μαρίαν
12. ὁ Ἰωνῆς ἀγαπᾷ Μαρίμουν
13. Ἰωνῆς ἀγαπᾷ ἡ Μαρίαν
14. Ἰωνῆς ἀγαπᾷ ἡ Μαρίμουν
15. Ἰωνῆς ἀγαπᾷ Μαρίαν
16. Ἰωνῆς ἀγαπᾷ Μαρίμουν